

Christ Two Wills

doc-christ-two-wills
Christology · Person · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across many Bible texts
Subject covered by a category in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Christ possesses two wills (divine and human) corresponding to His two natures, working in harmony.

In plain language

When Jesus prays in Gethsemane, the Greek puts two willings side by side using sharp contrast words. Luke 22:42 reads, 'not my will but yours,' where 'my' (mou) and 'yours' (son) point to two different owners of one and the same noun 'will' (thelema), joined by the contrast words 'however' (plen) and 'but' (alla), which signal a real opposition rather than a polite turn of phrase. Matthew 26:39 keeps the pattern with the pronouns 'I' (ego) and 'you' (su), each governing the verb 'I will' (thelo), and Mark 14:36 preserves the same shape. A verse later, Matthew 26:42 drops the 'my' entirely and prays only, 'your will be done,' showing the speaker's distinct will being brought to enact the Father's. John 6:38 and John 5:30 widen it: the speaker says he came not to do his own will ('the will, the mine' / to thelema to emon) but the will of the one who sent him ('the will of the one having sent me' / to thelema tou pempantos me), with the word 'will' (thelema) written twice in one breath. The same noun elsewhere clearly names a human will, 'the will of the flesh' and 'of man' in John 1:13, so the Son's own will is not just the divine will under a second name. That is why the pattern supports two distinct willings harmonized through submission. The honest limit is this: the text draws the contrast between two persons, the praying Son and the Father, not in so many words between two wills lodged in one person. A reader could take it as the man Jesus yielding his will to the one shared will of God. The words show a real human willing set under the divine will and brought into agreement with it, but whether each willing is tied to a specific nature is a framing the vocabulary alone does not settle, which is why this lands as supported but at medium confidence.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0235	ἀλλά	alla	but	763
G1014	βούλομαι	boulomai	to plan	40
G1096	γίνομαι	ginomai	to be	697
G1473	ἐγώ	egō	I/we	908
G1510	εἰμι	eimi	to be	
G2307	θέλημα	thelēma	will/desire	63
G2309	θέλω	thelō	to will/desire	214
G2597	καταβαίνω	katabainō	to come/go down	82
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	426
G3992	πέμπω	pempō	to send	81

G4133	πλήν	plēn	but/however	49
G4221	ποτήριον	potērion	cup	34
G4336	προσεύχομαι	proseuchomai	to pray	
G4771	σύ	sy	you	3,085

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Across the Gethsemane prayer and the Johannine sending sayings the Greek text repeatedly sets one occurrence of the will-noun against another with distinct possessors. Luke 22:42 has the praying Son say 'not my will but yours be done' (me to thelema mou alla to son ginestho), marking the speaker's will by the 'of me' genitive (mou, a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form) and the Father's by 'yours' (son), joined by the strong contrast words 'however' (plen) and 'but' (alla). John 6:38 and John 5:30 use the word for 'will' (thelema) twice with the article 'the', placing 'the will, the mine' (to thelema to emon) over against 'the will of the one having sent me' (to thelema tou pempantos me), with 'not' (ouch or ou) followed by 'but' (alla). Matthew 26:39 and Mark 14:36 carry the same shape with the pronouns 'I' (ego) and 'you' (su) governing the verb 'I will' (thelo). The vocabulary itself confirms the contrast is real, since 'will' (thelema) elsewhere names a genuine creaturely will (John 1:13, Ephesians 2:3, 1 Corinthians 7:37), so the Son's own 'will' (thelema) is not reducible to the divine will under another name. What the words do NOT state is the metaphysics (the underlying nature-and-person framework): the contrast they draw is person to person, the praying Son set beside the Father, not two wills lodged in one person mapped to two natures. That mapping is a downstream synthesis the lexical data underdetermine, which holds confidence at medium.

Scripture

Luke.22.42 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2307 θέλημα, G1014 βούλομαι, G4133 πλήν, G0235 αλλά, G3962 πατήρ, G4221 ποτήριον

Reasoning. Verified text: Πάτερ, εἰ βούλει παρένεγκε τοῦτο τὸ ποτήριον ἀπ' ἐμοῦ· πλήν μὴ τὸ θέλημά μου ἀλλὰ τὸ σὸν γινέσθω. In plain English: 'Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me; however, not my will but yours be done.' The praying Son distinguishes two owners of one and the same noun, 'will' (θέλημα, thelema): the first-person 'of me' genitive (a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form) (μου, mou) marks his own will, the possessive 'yours' (σόν, son) marks the Father's. The Father is addressed with the verb 'to deliberately wish' (βούλομαι, boulomai) in the phrase 'if you are willing' (εἰ βούλει, ei boulei), a verb the lexicon marks as the stronger deliberate volition, while the contrast is forced by both the strong adversative 'however' (πλήν, plen) and the disjunctive 'but' (ἀλλά, alla). The third-person imperative 'let it become' (γινέσθω, ginestho) locates the resolution in the Father's will being done while the speaker renounces his own. Asking for the non-fulfillment of one and the fulfillment of the other is incoherent if 'of me' (μου, mou) and 'yours' (σόν, son) name a single volition.

John.6.38 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2597 καταβαίνω, G2307 θέλημα, G3992 πέμπω, G0235 αλλά

Reasoning. Verified text: καταβέβηκα ἀπὸ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ οὐχ ἵνα ποιῶ τὸ θέλημα τὸ ἐμὸν ἀλλὰ τὸ θέλημα τοῦ πέμψαντός με. In plain English: 'I have come down from heaven not in order that I might do my own will but the will of the one who sent me.' The word 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) is articulated TWICE in one clause (each with the article 'the'), confirmed by token query (Strong's G2307 occurs twice here). The possessive adjective 'mine' (ἐμὸν, emon) marks one will-subject, the speaker, and the substantival genitive participle 'of the one having sent me' (τοῦ πέμψαντός με, tou pempantos me, a noun-functioning phrase in the 'from-X' grammatical form) marks another, the Father who sent. The 'not... but' (οὐχ... ἀλλά, ouch... alla) construction places the two articulated wills (each with the article 'the') side by side as distinct objects of doing, with the Son's purpose being to enact the sender's will rather than his own.

Matt.26.39 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4336 προσεύχομαι, G2309 θέλω, G1473 ἐγώ, G4771 σύ, G4221 ποτήριον

Reasoning. Verified text: Πάτερ μου, εἰ δυνατόν ἐστιν, παρελθάτω ἀπ' ἐμοῦ τὸ ποτήριον τοῦτο· πλὴν οὐχ ὡς ἐγὼ θέλω ἀλλ' ὡς σύ. In plain English: 'My Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass from me; however, not as I will but as you.' Two volitional pronominal subjects, 'I' (ἐγώ, ego) for the praying speaker and 'you' (σύ, su) for the Father, each govern the verb 'I will' (θέλω, thelo, the second occurrence left unspoken but implied). The 'if-then' conditional ('if-then' clause) 'if possible' (εἰ δυνατόν, ei dunaton) shows the request originates in the speaker's own desire, and the 'however' (πλὴν, plen) plus 'but' (ἀλλά, alla) disjunction submits that desire to a different will-bearer. Token query confirms Strong's G2309 (thelo, 'I will'), G1473 (ego, 'I'), G4771 (su, 'you'), G4133 (plen, 'however'), and G0235 (alla, 'but') are all present in this verse.

Matt.26.42 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2307 θέλημα, G3962 πατήρ, G1096 γίνομαι

Reasoning. Verified text: Πάτερ μου, εἰ οὐ δύναται τοῦτο παρελθεῖν ἐὰν μὴ αὐτὸ πίνω, γενηθήτω τὸ θέλημά σου. In plain English: 'My Father, if this cannot pass unless I drink it, your will be done.' The second Gethsemane prayer drops the contrastive 'of me' (μου, mou) entirely and now voices only 'let your will be done' (γενηθήτω τὸ θέλημά σου, genetheto to thelema sou), the identical petition form of Matthew 6:10 and Luke 11:2. This shows the resolution of the contrast: the speaker's distinct will, named in verse 39, is brought to enact the Father's will, 'yours' (σου, sou). The progression from verse 39 to verse 42 displays two willings moving into concord through submission rather than two names for one willing.

Mark.14.36 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2309 θέλω, G1473 ἐγώ, G4771 σύ, G3962 πατήρ

Reasoning. Verified text: Ἀββα ὁ πατήρ, πάντα δυνατά σοι· παρένεγκε τὸ ποτήριον τοῦτο ἀπ' ἐμοῦ· ἀλλ' οὐ τί ἐγὼ θέλω ἀλλὰ τί σύ. In plain English: 'Abba, Father, all things are possible for you; remove this cup from me; yet not what I will but what you.' The Markan parallel preserves the same two pronominal will-bearers, 'I' (ἐγώ, ego) and 'you' (σύ, su), governing the verb 'I will' (θέλω, thelo), with the Aramaic 'Abba' (Αββα) plus 'the Father' (ὁ πατήρ, ho pater) naming the second subject as the Father. Token query confirms Strong's G2309 (thelo, 'I will'), G1473 (ego, 'I'), G4771 (su, 'you'), and G0235 (alla, 'but') are present. The disjunction matches the Lukan and Matthean anchor verses.

John.5.30 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2307 θέλημα, G3992 πέμπω, G1473 ἐγώ

Reasoning. Verified text: Οὐ δύναμαι ἐγὼ ποιεῖν ἅπ' ἑμαυτοῦ οὐδέν. ὅτι οὐ ζητῶ τὸ θέλημα τὸ ἑμὸν ἀλλὰ τὸ θέλημα τοῦ πέμψαντός με. In plain English: 'I am not able to do anything from myself, because I do not seek my own will but the will of the one who sent me.' Same lexical pattern as John 6:38: the word 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) is set against 'mine' (ἐμὸν, emon) and the participial genitive 'of the one having sent me' (τοῦ πέμψαντός με, tou pempantos me, a noun-functioning phrase in the 'from-X' grammatical form), with the 'not... but' (οὐ... ἀλλά, ou... alla) disjunction making the contrast real. The opening 'I am not able to do anything from myself' (οὐ δύναμαι ἐγὼ ποιεῖν ἅπ' ἑμαυτοῦ οὐδέν, ou dunamai ego poiein ap' emautou ouden) qualifies the source, not the existence, of the Son's willing.

John.4.34 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2307 θέλημα, G3992 πέμπω

Reasoning. Verified text: Ἐμὸν βρῶμά ἐστιν ἵνα ποιήσω τὸ θέλημα τοῦ πέμψαντός με καὶ τελειώσω αὐτοῦ τὸ ἔργον. In plain English: 'My food is that I may do the will of the one who sent me and complete his work.' The Son identifies an external object of obedience, 'the will of the one who sent me' (τὸ θέλημα τοῦ πέμψαντός με, to thelema tou pempantos me), distinct from his own act of doing it (the verb 'I will do' / ποιήσω, poieso, first person). This presupposes a will-bearer other than the speaker whose 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) the speaker performs.

Heb.10.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2307 θέλημα

Reasoning. Verified text: τότε εἶπον· Ἴδοὺ ἤκω, ἐν κεφαλίδι βιβλίου γέγραπται περὶ ἐμοῦ, τοῦ ποιῆσαι, ὁ θεός, τὸ θέλημά σου. In plain English: 'Then I said, Behold, I have come, in the scroll of the book it is written about me, to do, O God, your will.' Citing Psalm 40, where the underlying Hebrew (Psalm 40:9 in the Masoretic Text) uses 'good pleasure or favor' (רצון, ratson, will) and 'to delight in' (צהה, chaphets, desire), confirmed by token query, the speaker subordinates his own coming to the doing of another's 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) addressed to God ('yours' / σου, sou). This is the one place the will-of-God concept reaches back into the Writings (the third division of the Hebrew Bible), though the contrastive TWO-wills grammar itself is confined to the Gospels.

John.1.13 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2307 θέλημα

Reasoning. Verified text: οἱ οὐκ ἐξ αἱμάτων οὐδὲ ἐκ θελήματος σαρκὸς οὐδὲ ἐκ θελήματος ἀνδρὸς ἀλλ' ἐκ θεοῦ ἐγεννήθησαν. In plain English: 'Who were born not of bloods nor of the will of flesh nor of the will of man but of God.' This verse is not about Christ but is load-bearing for triangulating the sense of the word: it shows 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) plainly denoting a genuine human will, 'will of flesh' (θέλημα σαρκός, thelema sarkos) and 'will of man' (θέλημα ἀνδρός, thelema andros), set against the will of God ('of God' / ἐκ θεοῦ, ek theou). The same word that names the Son's own will in John 5:30 and 6:38 is the word the canon uses for creaturely volition, so the Son's 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) is not reducible to the divine will under a second label.

John.10.30 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1510 εἰμι

Reasoning. Verified text: ἐγὼ καὶ ὁ πατήρ ἓν ἐσμεν. In plain English: 'I and the Father are one.' The neuter 'one' (ἓν, hen, meaning 'one thing,' not 'one person') with the plural verb 'we are' (ἐσμεν, esmen) asserts unity without collapsing the two grammatical subjects 'I' (ἐγώ, ego) and 'the Father' (ὁ πατήρ, ho pater). Pressed for unity of will, the verse lexically preserves two volitional referents acting in concord rather than erasing them.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.26.39	2Sam.15.26	tsk	1

Matt.26.39	Gen.17.3	tsk	1
John.6.38	John.4.34	tsk	1
Luke.22.42	Luke.22.17	tsk	1
Luke.22.42	Ps.40.8	tsk	1
Matt.26.39	2Sam.15.26	openbible	5
John.6.38	John.4.34	openbible	2

Complicating texts

John.10.30 · addressed

The unity assertion uses the neuter 'one' (έν, hen, meaning 'one thing') with the plural verb 'we are' (έσμεν, esmen), which lexically preserves two grammatical subjects rather than collapsing them. It asserts oneness of essence or action without erasing the two referents that elsewhere carry distinct 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) ascriptions, so it does not overturn the contrastive pattern of Luke 22:42, John 5:30, and John 6:38. Verified verbatim in the store.

John.5.19 · addressed

Verified text: οὐ δύναται ὁ υἱὸς ποιεῖν ἄφ' ἑαυτοῦ οὐδέν. In plain English: 'The Son is not able to do anything from himself.' This could be read as denying any independent volition in the Son. Lexically, however, 'from himself' (ἀφ' ἑαυτοῦ, aph' heautou) negates origin or autonomy of source, not the existence of the Son's willing capacity, since the same context has the Son seeing and then doing, which presupposes a real subjective agent. The verse modifies the RELATION between two wills, one derivative and one originating, rather than denying that there are two.

Phil.2.13 · unaddressed

Verified text: θεὸς γὰρ ἔστιν ὁ ἐνεργῶν ἐν ὑμῖν καὶ τὸ θέλειν καὶ τὸ ἐνεργεῖν ὑπὲρ τῆς εὐδοκίας. In plain English: 'For God is the one working in you both to will and to work for the sake of good pleasure.' The articular infinitive 'the willing' (τὸ θέλειν, to thelein, the act of willing, with the article 'the') is addressed to believers, not to the incarnate Son, and is sometimes generalized to argue that divine working absorbs creaturely willing. Whether the grammar of divine energizing of human 'to will' (θέλειν, thelein) here parallels or differs from the Son's volitional grammar was not resolved from the bundle, since the verse never names the Son and supplies no contrastive construction, so it remains an open lexical question rather than a settled counter-witness.

Concordance traversed

G2307, G2309, G1014, G0235, G4133, G1473, G4771, G3992, G3962, G4221, G2597, G1096

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

luke-22-42-43-44-block at Luke.22.42: impact none. The disputed block at Luke 22:43-44 (angel and bloody sweat) is not part of the will-saying itself. Verse 42 with the 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) contrast and the marked variants at 'remove' (παρένεγκε, parenegke) and 'let it become' (γινέσθω, ginestho) is textually stable across the major witnesses for the contrast that carries the verdict.

matt-26-39-word-order at Matt.26.39: impact none. Minor word-order and orthographic variants ('let it pass' / παρελθάτω, parelthato, versus παρελθέτω, paretheto; 'having come' / προελθών, proelthon, versus προσελθών, proselthon) do not affect the 'however, not as I will but as you' (πλὴν οὐχ ὡς ἐγὼ θέλω ἀλλ' ὡς σύ, plen ouch hos ego thelo all' hos su) contrast.

john-6-38-apo-ek at John.6.38: impact none. Variation between 'from' (ἀπό, apo) and 'out of' (ἐκ, ek) before 'the heaven' (τοῦ οὐρανοῦ, tou ouranou) does not alter the 'not in order that I might do my own will but the will of the

one who sent me' (οὐχ ἵνα ποιῶ τὸ θέλημα τὸ ἐμὸν ἀλλὰ τὸ θέλημα τοῦ πέμψαντός με, ouch hina poio to thelema to emon alla to thelema tou pempantos me) contrast, which preserves both articulated occurrences of 'will' (θέλημα, thelema).

Each anchor verse lies outside the published ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) volumes (3 John only), so 'not_in_ecm_scope' is true for all anchors. Variant assessment uses the surface apparatus markings on the stored SBLGNT text. CBGM-grade evaluation (the genealogical method used by the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) deferred.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. incarnational_christology, trinitarian_relations

analogia scripturae invoked

dyothelite_reading: supported · Two articulated occurrences of 'will' (θέλημα, thelema, each with the article 'the') with distinct possessors (John 6:38, John 5:30), the 'not... but' (οὐχ... ἀλλά, ouch... alla) and 'however' (πλὴν, plen) disjunctions, the contrast of 'I' (ἐγώ, ego) and 'you' (σύ, su) over the verb 'I will' (θέλω, thelo) in Matthew 26:39 and Mark 14:36, and the fact that 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) independently names a real human will (John 1:13, Ephesians 2:3, 1 Corinthians 7:37) give a consistent grammatical pattern of a distinct human willing submitting to the divine will.

monothelite_reading: underdetermined · The strongest single-will reading holds that the contrast is between two PERSONS, the praying man Jesus and the Father, not between two wills inside one person. On this reading 'of me' (μου, mou) and 'yours' (σόν, son) name the speaker over against his addressee, and the will being submitted is the human Jesus's will set under the one shared will of the triune God, so the text shows a man's will yielding to God's will, not a second will in the divine Son. The vocabulary does not by itself decide between a distinct human faculty and a personal contrast, which is why the metaphysical claim (about the underlying nature-and-person framework) remains underdetermined by the words alone.

kenotic_reading: compatible · A reading that locates the human 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) in the incarnate Son's assumed condition fits the grammar, since the praying speaker has a genuine desire ('if you are willing' / εἰ βούλει, ei boulei, and 'if possible' / εἰ δυνατόν, ei dunaton) that he subordinates. This is compatible with the lexical pattern but layers a theological account of the incarnation over it rather than reading it off the words.

The verdict rests on grammatical contrast within Synoptic and Johannine prayer and discourse material. The cross-references to 2 Samuel 15:26 and Psalm 40:8 support the structural pattern of a speaker submitting his own will to another's, and Psalm 40:9 in the Masoretic Text supplies the Old Testament will-vocabulary ('good pleasure or favor' / ratson, רצון, and 'to delight in' / chaphets, צפח) behind Hebrews 10:7, but the verdict does not depend on those links.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Christ in the Gospels speaks of his own 'will' (θέλημα, thelema) as distinguishable from the Father's 'will' (θέλημα, thelema), contrasting them with disjunctive particles and submitting one to the other.

The clause 'corresponding to His two natures' imports conciliar dyothelite taxonomy (the church-council framework of two wills mapped to two natures) into the stem. The phrase 'two wills' is itself not in the canon, so this is a synthesis proposition. The lexical evidence supports the existence of a distinguishable human willing in Christological speech that submits to the divine will, but it does not by itself establish the metaphysical mapping (the underlying nature-and-person framework) of each will to a nature within one person.

VERDICT-CHANGED: The verdict is derived on the original stem with this caveat noted, and confidence is held at medium because the words draw a person-to-person contrast that the two-wills-in-one-person metaphysics extends beyond.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2307

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2309
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1014
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2307
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Luke.22.42
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.26.39
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.6.38
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.14.36
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	Luke.22.42
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	John.6.38
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	Matt.26.42
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	John.5.30
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	John.1.13
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	Heb.10.7
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.40.9
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.26.39
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Luke.22.42
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	John.6.38

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Flags

ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved